

SOFTENG 761: Advanced Agile and Lean Software Development

Rationale Investigation 1 (3% of final grade)

Due: 9pm, 30th July 2026 (Middle of Week 2)

Learning Outcomes

The purpose of this assignment is to target the following learning outcomes:

- *Infer, identify and explain* underlying rationales from minimal project descriptions,
- *Critically examine* online information to illustrate project significance,
- *Organise* your investigation into *concise* and *convincing* flow, backed by appropriate evidence.

Speed Rationales

This assignment is about developing the skills to quickly and efficiently research project descriptions, and to demonstrate a deeper appreciation for what their rationale could be. As of this moment, all we have from the clients are whatever descriptions that they proposed, in terms of the idea of what they (think) they would like developed. In some cases, these descriptions are specific around the tool/application they would like to see, in some cases there are more information than other descriptions. We have to accept this is all we have to go by for now.

Here's what you need to do:

1. From the project topics on offer, pick any *three* that you want.
2. Write your answers in the allocated space in Canvas. There is a section to complete for each topic you select. Be sure to write the title of the topics to make it clear which ones you selected.
3. For each of the three topics you selected, you should aim to write *a series of bullet points* (across about 200 words for each of the topics you select). No paragraphs. Each bullet point is at most a single line. These don't have to be complete sentences—they can be similar to bullet points on a powerpoint presentation.
4. Based on these descriptions, you are to infer the proposed rationale of each topic. Make sure you read carefully the lecture content¹ about rationales. Why is the topic important? Is there a crisis of some sort? Is the rationale in regards to some economic, social, diversity, equity, etc implication?

¹Canvas Modules 1 & 2/project-rationale

5. The sequence of bullet points should appear to follow a narrative. There should be a flow between the bullet points and ideas underpinning each of them. Sometimes it is useful to think of the flow being an upside-down triangle, where your ideas start talking about “broad and general” ideas, and slowly narrowing down to being more specific about the topics.
6. It should be clear from your flow as to why you have selected the topic. It needs to be apparent from the way you write that there’s something important about it. What this means is, what you write about the topic should be clearly meaningful for someone else to care about it also.
7. You do NOT need to do any research in terms of a literature review or anything. It is fine to base this flow off a “gut-instinct hunch of ideas” that you feel works well. You will find it useful to do a few quick web searches to strengthen your flow and connections between the bullet points.
8. Do NOT use personal language, such as “*I chose to write about this project because it is close at heart to me*” etc. You should also not use personal justifications, such as “*This topic is important because it means I will no longer be late arriving to work*”. Both of these sorts of language and “justifications” make for a weak rationale, as it appears that only YOU (the author) actually cares about this topic (and that’s why you are writing using such a personal tone or reasoning). Instead, you need to emphasise the importance of the rationale more strongly (e.g., globally-relevant, or touching a large community or audience rather than just a few people). The “*Who cares?*” needs to be evident. Make the reader convinced that they should also care about this topic, that it has wider implications.
9. You should not be discussing anything around “the solution” (or the product that the client is trying to describe). Focus only on the bigger-picture rationale and context underpinning the topic. This means you will most likely not even make mention of “the thing” that the client has described they want you to implement. Focus on the underlying problem.
10. You might want to do a little bit of research, for example searching for some authoritative stats or data that you can mention. It does not need to be academic articles (in fact, for this report it is preferred not to be academic documents as we want to be quick here and just try to get a first rough draft of the key ideas). This document needs to be a “quick stop” summary of the rationales for the three topics you selected.

Using ChatGPT

You are more than welcome to use ChatGPT to help complete this assignment. Using ChatGPT to improve your productivity is a valuable skill in itself. All you need to do is elaborate how you used it. No matter how you used it, you won’t be penalised — so don’t worry! There is a dedicated section in the assignment for you to complete and elaborate how you used ChatGPT. You can include some of the prompts you used, and/or describe your process using it. It’s a valuable learning exercise to reflect on how it was useful to improve your productivity.

Submission and Formatting

- Submit in Canvas using the A1 Quiz.
- For each topic, make sure to write the topic's title (use one of the "Heading" formats in Canvas). Immediately below it, use bullet pointing.
- Each bullet point should be brief. A bullet point is a single line. Do not write "paragraphs" as bullet points. You want to make it easy for the reader to skim through the narrative/flow of points.
- Aim for about 200 words per topic, but broken down in bullet points.
- If your responses are noticeably short, this won't appear like you a good flow of strong and convincing rationales.

Marking Rubric

The assignment will be marked out of 15 marks, and will be scaled to 3% of the course:

- Content (12 marks in total – 4 marks for each topic):
 - The "So what?" is apparent, the importance/significance of wider topic area.
 - The "Who cares?" is apparent, globally-relevant or a large community, convincing.
 - There's a clear flow of ideas linking the bullet points.
 - Avoid discussing anything around "the solution" (e.g., the software application). Stick to the vision.
- ChatGPT reflection (2 marks):
 - Elaborate how ChatGPT was used. Where was it useful? Where was it not useful?
- Writing (1 mark)
 - Avoids personal or casual language/tone.
 - Correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation etc.

Late Submissions

Late submissions for this assignment will incur the following penalties:

- 10% penalty for zero to 12 hours late,
- 20% penalty for 13 to 24 hours late,
- 100% penalty for over 24 hours late (Canvas Quiz automatically closes).

Academic Honesty

- The work done on this assignment must be your (and/or ChatGPT's) own work. Not your friend's work (unless ChatGPT is your only friend).
- **The submission will be checked using Turnitin.** This will not only compare your submission with online and academic databases, but it will also compare between your peers' submissions. These submissions will be entered and saved into the Turnitin collection, and will therefore be compared against past and future submissions. Submissions with suspicious similarity will result in an Investigative Meeting, and will be forwarded to the Disciplinary Committee.
- Penalties for copying will be severe – to avoid being caught copying, don't do it.
- To ensure you are not identified as breaching academic conduct, you should follow these points:
 - Elaborate how you used ChatGPT. Remember, you are allowed (and encouraged) to use ChatGPT for this assignment. Just elaborate and reflect how it was used.
 - Always do individual assignments by yourself.
 - Never show or give another person your submission.
 - Keep your workspace private, and do not share your documents with anyone.
 - Never put your work in a public place (e.g., Reddit, public GitHub repository, forums, your website).
 - Never leave your computer unattended. You are responsible for the security of your account.
 - Ensure you always remove your USB flash drive from the computer before you log off.